ATS-Aware CV Formatting Guide

How to format a construction CV so screening systems and recruiters can actually read it. Advisory guidance only - no formatting can guarantee screening outcomes.

What screening systems do

- Parse your CV into structured text: titles, employers, dates, skills, education
- Let recruiters search and filter by keywords and job titles
- Sometimes rank or summarise applications against the advert

Formatting that helps

- Single-column layout, top-to-bottom reading order
- Standard headings: Profile, Experience, Education, Skills
- Contact details typed in the body, not in headers/footers/images
- Clear date ranges for every role (e.g. "Mar 2019 - Jun 2023")
- Common fonts (Arial, Calibri, Helvetica), 10-12pt
- Bullet points using plain round/square bullets

Formatting that hurts

- Multi-column templates and text boxes (content read out of order)
- Skill bars, icons and charts instead of words
- Photos and decorative graphics in portal versions
- Tables for layout
- Unusual fonts and dense formatting

File types

- PDF parses well in most modern systems
- Some portals prefer Word (.docx) - keep both versions
- Best practice: one designed PDF for humans, one plain version for portals

The honest rule

Never use hidden white text, pasted job adverts or keyword stuffing.
It is unethical, detectable, and destroys recruiter trust instantly.

Construct CV - linkedinconstructioncvprofile.com / Upload CV page